Evil Partnerships

At 01.44 on 5 April 1986, three people were killed and 153 injured, including sixty Americans, when a powerful bomb exploded in a packed West Berlin nightclub popular with US servicemen. The La Belle club in the American sector was torn apart in what was the most shocking and disturbing crime in Berlin for a decade. No one took responsibility for the blast, but intelligence reports filtering through to President Reagan led the United States to blame the attack on Libyans working from East Berlin. As the news broke, phone calls ricocheted back and forth between Honecker and Mielke. It was established that the American evidence stemmed from an intercepted telephone call between Colonel Ghaddafi and diplomats at the Libyan mission in East Berlin, linking Ghaddafi directly to the atrocity. The story became even murkier when it later emerged that Honecker, Krenz and Axen were said to have been briefed in 1985 about a planned attack by Libyan terrorists on a US establishment in West Berlin.1

According to Stern, the Stasi had warned Honecker repeatedly of a possible bomb attack but by one means or another, he issued repeated instructions not to interfere. In other words, let them get on with it.2 Even after the incident, he allegedly gave instructions to be kept up to date about operational measures but asked Stasi agents to do nothing which might harm relations with Libya.

Die Welt went further, reporting that a Stasi colonel who, following the attack, wanted to put an end to the activities of the terrorists, was unceremoniously dismissed on the instructions of the SED leadership.3 In the tumult, Bruce W. Clark, a US Political Advisor on East Germany with the State Department office on Central European Affairs, remembered the US ambassador, Frank Meehan, paying a visit to the Foreign Ministry to ask the GDR to act against the Libyan embassy in East Berlin. 'The officials told him that they had no idea what he was talking about, and if his accusations were true, it was just shocking.'4 Looking back, Markus Wolf thought the bombing was the 'logical culmination' of the decision to allow